Silo System: Player's Survival Guide

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31 August 2026

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Silo System: Player's Survival Guide

"We do not know why we are here. We do not know who built the Silo. We only know that the world outside is dead, and the Silo is life."

Welcome to the Silo. This is your entire universe. It is a massive, subterranean cylinder of concrete and steel, extending 144 levels deep into the earth. There are no elevators. A single, colossal spiral staircase acts as the central artery for thousands of citizens.

You have never seen the sun, felt rain, or breathed un-recycled air. You wear patched clothes woven from hydroponic cotton. You eat processed soy, algae paste, and if you are very lucky, a morsel of rabbit meat. You work a grueling 12-hour shift, turning valves, hauling freight, or balancing ledgers to ensure the survival of the collective.

The Silo is a pressure cooker of scarcity, bureaucracy, and paranoia. Survival means keeping your head down, doing your job, and never, ever questioning the nature of your confinement.

The Three Absolute Truths

Every child in the Silo is taught these three truths from the moment they can speak. To question them is not just illegal; it is treated as a dangerous mental illness.

1. The Outside Is Death

The world above is a toxic, blasted wasteland. The only window to this world is the "Viewport" in the Level 1 Cafeteria—a massive screen hooked to an external camera. It shows a landscape of ruined, dead hills beneath a grey, swirling sky, littered with the rotting bodies of those who came before. The air outside will melt your lungs in minutes.

2. The Pact Is Law

There is no constitution, no bill of rights, and no forgiving judge. There is only **The Pact**. It is a massive, ancient legal text that dictates every aspect of your life. It dictates how many children can be born, the required thread count of a mechanic's coveralls, and the exact punishment for stealing a ration of water. Judicial clerks enforce The Pact with terrifying, absolute authority.

3. The Cleaning Is Our Burden

The ultimate punishment for any major crime—or for uttering the forbidden words, *"I want to go outside"*—is The Cleaning. The condemned is fitted with a hazmat suit and sent out the airlock to die. But before they die, as the toxic air eats through their suit, they are compelled by some profound, tragic realization to take a wool pad and clean the lenses of

the Silo's external cameras. They wipe away the grime so those inside can clearly see the wasteland, reminding everyone why they must stay inside.

The World You Know (the Three Sectors)

You likely rarely leave a tight three-level radius around your home and workplace. Traveling more than ten levels is an exhausting journey requiring packed rations and canteens of water. Because of this, the Silo is fiercely divided by geography.

Up Top (Levels 1–48)

- **The Vibe:** Clean air, bright halogen lights, white walls, and the smell of sterile floor wax.
- **The People:** The elite. The Mayor, the Sheriff, the Judicial clerks, and the IT department live and work here. They speak with formal, crisp accents. They wear clean blues and whites. To the rest of the Silo, they are privileged, out-of-touch bureaucrats who don't know what it takes to keep the lights on.
- **The Danger:** Surveillance. Up Top, there are cameras everywhere. Everyone is watching everyone else. A misplaced word here can get you arrested by the Sheriff's deputies before you even reach the stairs.

The Mids (Levels 49–96)

- **The Vibe:** Humid, crowded, and smelling permanently of damp earth, fertilizer, and unwashed bodies.
- **The People:** The working class. This sector houses the sprawling hydroponic farms, the Medical wards, the Nurseries, and the massive Supply depots. The people here are pragmatic, territorial, and fiercely loyal to their local levels. They wear practical greens and browns.
- **The Danger:** Starvation and disease. If a crop blights or a water filter fails, the Mids suffer first and worst. Life here is a constant hustle, trading favors and "chits" (currency) to get by.

Down Deep (Levels 97–144)

- **The Vibe:** Sweltering heat, the deafening roar of machinery, and the taste of metallic dust and crude oil in the air. Dimly lit by bare emergency bulbs.

- **The People:** The "grease." Mechanics, miners, and oil drillers. They are physically imposing, covered in permanent grease stains, and speak "Deep Talk"—a guttural slang that cuts through the noise of the generator. They resent the Up Top elites who reap the benefits of their backbreaking labor.
- **The Danger:** Industrial death. A bursting steam pipe, a collapsed mine shaft, or a failing air scrubber are daily threats. The Down Deep is dangerous, but the people there know that without them, the entire Silo dies in the dark.

How the Silo Feels to Live In

You do not think in blueprints. You think in stairs, queues, walls, and how long your legs will hurt afterward.

What a Typical Level Contains

A level is usually not one single room. It is a ring of spaces wrapped around the central stair:

- **The stair landing:** The public face of the level, where people pass through, rest, trade gossip, and get seen.
- **The inner corridors:** Pipes, ducts, maintenance doors, and utility access closer to the core.
- **The lived spaces:** Apartments, offices, workshops, farms, clinics, storage rooms, or tank galleries depending on the level's purpose.
- **The outer wall:** Thick concrete, patched wiring, narrow storage niches, and the constant sense that the earth is pressing in from the other side.

On a residential level, this means cramped homes, shared wash areas, and hallway politics. On a work level, it means noise, quota boards, foremen, and people who resent outsiders slowing things down.

The Distance Between Levels

There are about **50 stairs between official levels**.

- **1-3 levels:** local movement
- **5-10 levels:** a real trip
- **10+ levels:** something people complain about afterward
- **20+ levels:** an undertaking unless you are a Porter, on official business, or desperate

That is why citizens often talk about a level as if it were another town. Practically speaking, it is.

Split Levels, Half-Levels, and Dead Spaces

Most citizens know that not every part of the Silo makes clean sense.

- **Split levels:** A level can feel socially split even when it has only one official number. One side may be residential while the other is tanks, workshops, or storage.
- **Half-levels and service spaces:** People speak of utility bands, maintenance galleries, and sealed access rooms that seem to sit between official levels. Most citizens never enter them and are not meant to ask questions.
- **Structural seams:** Some levels feel different underfoot—louder, more flexible, more patched. People say the Silo is breathing.
- **Dead spaces:** Crawlways, vent chambers, flooded rooms, and abandoned corners that physically exist but do not appear on any public map.

The first few sessions of play should turn these from rumors into places you actually know.

The Local Radius (Where Many Citizens Actually Live)

Most citizens know the whole Silo only in the abstract. What they know *personally* is a cluster of floors, routes, queues, and faces. If you are from the late Mids or the shallow Down Deep, the following levels likely mean something to you.

Levels	What People Think Of Them
45-50	The upper Mids where paperwork hardens into fate: transfer manifests, marriage approvals, and long waits outside Supply offices.
60-80	The Hydroponics rings: humid air, artificial suns, soy vats, algae stink, and workers who know exactly how many mouths depend on every tray.
79-85	Narrow stairs, tank rooms, and maintenance access where water, rumor, and panic move faster than officials do.

Levels	What People Think Of Them
92	A hard-lived residential seam where families double up, walls crack, and every repair becomes political.
101-105	The start of the true Deep: flooded scrap tiers, illegal deals, failing lights, jury-rigged pumps, and the feeling that official help is already too far away.

Faces You Know by Reputation

You may never have met these people, but if you live in this part of the Silo, you have heard their names.

The Famous People Everyone Knows

- **Mayor Tamsin Rook:** The official voice of the Silo. Lower-tier citizens know her as an old, careful leader who appears during speeches, crises, and public rituals. People argue constantly about whether she is powerless, wise, or simply too far away to matter.
- **Chief Deputy Harlan Fiske:** The Sheriff's hard edge. He is known as the man who appears when a problem has already become serious. In common talk, his name means inspections, arrests, and "don't be stupid on the stairs."
- **Inquisitor Sel Verin:** A senior Judicial name spoken with caution. Even people who have never seen him know he is tied to investigations, sealed orders, and the kind of legal attention that ruins whole families.
- **Merrow Hale, Head of IT:** More rumor than man to most lower-level citizens. People know IT answers to him, that his levels are cold and quiet, and that asking too many questions about computers is a good way to get noticed.
- **Tavi Rune (Porters' Union):** Famous in a more practical way than the officials above. If you live by the stairs, you know that when Tavi speaks, messages move, prices shift, and people start choosing their words carefully.
- **Auntie Cinder (Scrap Syndicates):** Half criminal, half folk-devil. Children hear stories about her, adults pretend not to know her name, and everyone understands that if real parts appear on a dead level, her people probably touched them first.
- **Matron Ysra Thorn (Hydroponics):** A public face of food, quotas, and harvest

pressure. She is respected by workers, blamed by the hungry, and spoken of like a weather pattern: if she says a cycle will be hard, everyone listens.

The Local Faces People Actually Talk About

- **Nel Ardin (Supply Clerk):** A tired, decent clerk from the Mids who sometimes "loses" the right form for the right people. Known for helping when he should probably keep his head down.
- **The Miller Clan:** Not a single person but a whole family whose arguments spill into hallways, repair queues, and housing ledgers. If you live near the seams, you know at least one Miller story.
- **Rella Voss:** The sort of hallway organizer every struggling tier eventually produces: practical, loud when necessary, and impossible to ignore during a crisis.
- **Inspector Dorn:** A name people use when they mean the lower-level face of Mechanical oversight. Not famous across the whole Silo, but well known in the Deep as the kind of inspector who can ruin your week or save your floor.

Groups, Families, and Factions People Talk About

These are not hidden conspiracies. They are the names that come up in queues, workshops, and communal kitchens.

- **The Miller Clan:** A large, stubborn family from the residential seams. Loud, proud, always entangled in somebody else's housing dispute.
- **The Porters' Union:** Not officially in charge of anything, which is why they know everything. If they stop carrying, the Silo chokes.
- **The Scrap Syndicates:** Smugglers, gamblers, fixers, and thieves. Everyone condemns them in public and knows someone who has bought from them in private.
- **Block Watches:** Unofficial hallway defense groups formed when the Sheriff is too slow, too absent, or too expensive to trust.
- **Hydroponics Crews:** Territorial work gangs held together by quota pressure, exhausted loyalty, and the knowledge that one bad cycle means hunger for everyone.
- **The Friends of the Silo:** Informants, loyalists, fanatics, opportunists, or all four at once. No one can agree who belongs to them, which is part of their power.

Landmarks in the Late Mids and Shallow Deep

Place	Why It Matters
The Level 50 Supply Offices	Where forms go to be approved, buried, or quietly altered.
The Level 60 Porter Landings	A crossroads of gossip, freight, and exhausted runners drinking brackish water before another climb.
The Algae Vats (around Level 72)	Green-lit humidity, long shifts, and the smell of survival itself.
The Water Stations (around Levels 80-84)	The heart of daily arguments: lines, ration disputes, contamination scares, and whispered rumors.
The Seam Apartments (Level 92)	Cramped family housing where repairs are never complete and everyone knows too much about everyone else.
The Flooded Tier (Level 101)	A half-ruined scrap market where good parts, bad debts, and dangerous people all circulate together.
The Dark Tier (Level 105)	A level used in complaints and warnings: failing lights, stale air, and the sense that the Deep is swallowing one more block.

Your Place in the Machine (Character Roles)

When you create your character, you aren't an adventurer. You are a citizen with a job. Who are you in the machine?

- **The Porter:** You are the postal service, the freight train, and the rumor mill. Porters run the stairs all day, carrying goods and messages. You have incredible stamina, calves of steel, and you know the layout of the Silo better than anyone. You also hear *everything.*
- **The Mechanic:** You keep the beast breathing. Whether you work on the great Generator at Level 144, or fix the local air scrubbers in the Mids, you know how to jury-rig ancient technology with nothing but a wrench and scrap metal.
- **The Supply Clerk:** You are the master of red tape. You know exactly how many lightbulbs are on Level 40 and who is hoarding water on Level 60. You survive by

trading favors, manipulating the inventory ledgers, and knowing exactly who to bribe.

- **The Hydroponics Farmer:** You grow the food. You spend your days under artificial suns, tending to algae vats and soy plants. You are tough, protective of your yields, and possess a rare knowledge of biology and chemistry.
- **The IT Tech / Medical Assistant:** You belong to the educated class. You have access to the rare, functioning computers or the tightly controlled pharmaceutical cabinets. You have a slightly higher standard of living, but you are also much closer to the terrifying gaze of Judicial.

What Your Citizen Knows Without Asking

Even the most obedient citizen learns the following truths just by surviving:

- A trip of more than ten levels is not casual. You pack water, trade for a place to sleep, or hire a Porter if you can afford one.
- Paper beats memory. If a clerk has a stamped form and you only have the truth, the clerk wins.
- Every level has at least one fixer, one gossip, and one person everyone suspects is a Friend of the Silo.
- If the lights pulse off-schedule, people stop what they are doing. It usually means a death, a failure, or an order from above.
- Porters know the real geography. Mechanical knows which walls shake. Supply knows who is lying. Medical knows who is desperate. IT knows more than anyone admits.
- Children are "Gifted" names, not born with them. On their fifth birthday, if they survive, they inherit the name of a dead ancestor.

What a Normal Day Feels Like

Before the first few sessions of play turn your life upside down, this is what "normal" looks like:

- You wake to recycled air, queue for water, and check whether the lights are behaving normally.
- You go to shift because missing work hurts your whole household, not just your pride.
- You trade small favors all day: line-holding, message-carrying, tool-borrowing, ration-stretching.

- You hear two or three rumors before mid-cycle and believe at least one of them a little.
- You measure distance in sore legs, not maps.
- You end the day wondering whether the person across the hall is a friend, a burden, or an informant.

The first few sessions should answer the rest: who your block trusts, which levels you fear, what the local power map looks like, and what you are willing to do when the machinery of the Silo turns against ordinary people.

Session Zero Questions for Your Block

Use these prompts when building characters so the party feels like citizens from the same world instead of strangers who happened to meet.

1. Which person on your level depends on your wages to survive?
2. Which department do you distrust on principle, and what did they do to your family?
3. What minor law did you break as a child and get away with?
4. Who taught you how to survive the stairs, the queues, or the inspections?
5. What rumor about the Silo do you secretly hope is true?
6. What debt, favor, or shame keeps you from simply walking away from trouble?

Silo Slang and Common Sayings

Term	Meaning
Up-Top	Anything associated with privilege, surveillance, or clean-handed authority.
Down-Shift	A transfer to a lower level, often treated as exile even when technically voluntary.
Soft-Hands	A Deep insult for people who do paperwork instead of labor.
Grease	The Mechanics and other Down Deep workers who keep the Silo alive.
Shadow	An apprentice learning under a mentor; also slang for someone with no real power yet.

Term	Meaning
Good Tape	Any rare, high-quality repair material that official channels claim does not exist.
Dead Space	A vent, crawl, sealed room, or unregistered area that is absent from public maps.
Blue Water	Water that tastes "wrong" and is rumored to be drugged by Medical or Judicial.
Pact-Blind	Someone who obeys the law so rigidly that they stop seeing obvious cruelty.
"Mind the rail."	A warning to be careful, keep quiet, or stop asking dangerous questions.

A Final Warning

The Silo is not just a place; it is a living, breathing entity that wants to maintain the status quo at all costs.

As you go about your life, remember that Judicial commands a network of secret informants known as the **"Friends of the Silo."** They do not wear uniforms. They are your neighbor, the bartender who serves your synthetic gin, or the doctor setting your broken arm.

Keep your head down. Do not ask about the "Before" time. Do not horde relics of the old world. Do not ask why the IT servers are locked behind steel doors.

Protect your family, do your job, and never look too long at the Viewport.

Welcome to the Silo.